

# Noah E. Creany, PhD

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## Research

### Protected Area Conservation & Management

My expertise lies in Protected Area Conservation and Recreation Management, specifically applied, interdisciplinary research that integrates social science and ecology to inform management through a social-ecological systems lens.

- Recreation Ecology
  - Human Dimensions of Wildland Recreation
  - Visitor Use Management & Monitoring
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## Professional Experience

### Postdoctoral Research Fellow

2024-2026

*Oak Ridge Institute for Science and Education (ORISE)/ U.S. Forest Service*

- Designed an algorithmic optimization approach for the U.S. Forest Service National Visitor Use Monitoring (NVUM) program to reduce program costs for data collection while maintaining the fidelity and utility of data.
- Developed gradient-boosted regression model using novel monitoring data to predict site-level daily forest visitation, and computer-vision object-detection workflow for automated trail-use monitoring.

### Research Assistant

2017-2024

*Utah State University*

- Investigated recreation impacts on wildland ecosystems, employing advanced data analytics and machine learning techniques (Python, R) for regression, classification, and clustering.
  - Managed and analyzed complex multi-modal datasets, including spatial, tabular, survey, and raster/imagery data.
  - Collaborated with federal, state, and county land managers to ensure research deliverables met management priorities and timelines.
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## Education

### Utah State University

2020-2024

*PhD, Ecology*

*Logan, UT, USA*

- Research Assistant, Instructor of Record
- Dissertation: *Shifting Paradigms in Recreation and Parks and Protected Areas: Advancing Social-Ecological Systems Frameworks in Park and Protected Area Management*
- Major Professor: Dr. Christopher A. Monz, Supervising Committee: Dr. Mark Brunson, Dr. Wayne Freimund, Dr. Sarah Klain, Dr. Patrick Singleton.

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| <b>Utah State University</b><br><i>M.Sc., Recreation Resource Management</i><br>• Thesis: <i>Kudos &amp; KOMs: The Effect of Strava Use on Evaluations of Social and Managerial Conditions, Perceptions of Ecological Impacts, and Mountain Bike Spatial Behavior</i><br>• Research Assistant/Teaching Assistant                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | 2019<br>Logan, UT, USA           |
| <b>Pennsylvania State University</b><br><i>B.Sc., Community, Environment, and Development</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | 2012<br>University Park, PA, USA |
| <hr/>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                  |
| Funded Research                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                  |
| <b>City of Boulder Open Space and Mountain Parks (OSMP)</b><br><i>Developing computer-vision visitor use monitoring methodology - \$12,000</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | 2026                             |
| <b>Rocky Mountain National Park Day Use Visitor Access Monitoring</b><br><i>Rocky Mountain Conservancy \$15,000</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2025                             |
| <b>Rocky Mountain National Park Day Use Visitor Access Monitoring</b><br><i>Rocky Mountain Conservancy \$15,000</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2024                             |
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| Awards                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                  |
| <b>Utah State University Quinney College of Natural Resources</b><br><i>Doctoral Student Researcher of the Year</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2023                             |
| <b>Rocky Mountain Cooperative Ecosystem Studies Unit (CESU)</b><br><i>Student Researcher (Honorable Mention)</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | 2023                             |
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| Peer-Reviewed Articles                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                  |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Creany, N.,</b> Monz, C., &amp; Freimund, W. (2026). Strava Metro mobility data provides accurate estimates of recreation use in Urban-Proximate Protected Areas. <i>Journal of Outdoor Recreation and Tourism</i>. doi: 10.1016/j.jort.2025.101008</li> <li>• Van Deursen, J., <b>Creany, N.,</b> Monz, C. A., &amp; Freimund, W. (2025). Classifications of Recreation Specialization: Attitudinal and Behavioral Differences Across Specialization Types in the Nature Reserve of Orange County, CA, USA. <i>Journal of Park and Recreation Administration</i>. doi: 10.18666/JPRA-2025-12883</li> <li>• Wheeler, I., Blair, P., <b>Creany, N.,</b> Manire, H., Morris, D., Mollett, S., Scarce, S. S., Stoellinger, T., Willoughby, J. R., &amp; Dunning, K. H. (2025). Delisting the Northern Rocky Mountain gray wolf from the US Endangered Species Act: An assessment of political discourse over 20 years. <i>Wildlife Biology</i>. doi: 10.1002/wlb3.01589</li> <li>• <b>Creany, N.,</b> Monz, C. A., &amp; Esser, S. M. (2024). Understanding visitor attitudes towards the timed-entry reservation system in Rocky Mountain National Park: Contemporary managed access as a social-ecological system. <i>Journal of Outdoor Recreation and Tourism</i>. doi: 10.1016/j.jort.2024.100736</li> <li>• Minehart, K., Antonio, A. D., <b>Creany, N.,</b> Monz, C., &amp; Gutzwiller, K. (2024). Predicting trail condition using random forest models in urban-proximate nature reserves. <i>Environmental Challenges</i>. doi: 10.1016/j.envc.2024.100937</li> </ul> |                                  |

- Van Deursen, J., **Creany, N.**, Smith, B., Freimund, W., Avgar, T., & Monz, C. A. (2024). Recreation specialization: Resource selection functions as a predictive tool for protected area recreation management. *Applied Geography*. doi: 10.1016/j.apgeog.2024.103276
- Tomczyk, A. M., Ewertowski, M. W., **Creany, N.**, Ancin-Murguzur, F. J., & Monz, C. (2023). The application of unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV) surveys and GIS to the analysis and monitoring of recreational trail conditions. *International Journal of Applied Earth Observation and Geoinformation*. doi: 10.1016/j.jag.2023.103474
- **Creany, N.**, Monz, C. A., D'Antonio, A., Sisneros-Kidd, A., Wilkins, E. J., Nesbitt, J., & Mitrovich, M. (2021). Estimating trail use and visitor spatial distribution using mobile device data: An example from the nature reserve of orange county, California USA. *Environmental Challenges*. doi: 10.1016/j.envc.2021.100171
- Monz, C., **Creany, N.**, Nesbitt, J., & Mitrovich, M. (2021). Mobile Device Data Analysis to Determine the Demographics of Park Visitors. *Journal of Park and Recreation Administration*. doi: 10.18666/10.18666/JPRA-2020-10541
- Smith, J. W., Miller, A. B., Lamborn, C. C., Spornbauer, B. S., **Creany, N.**, Richards, J. C., Meyer, C., Nesbitt, J., Rempel, W., Wilkins, E. J., Miller, Z. D., Freimund, W., & Monz, C. (2021). Motivations and spatial behavior of OHV recreationists: A case-study from central Utah (USA). *Journal of Outdoor Recreation and Tourism*. doi: 10.1016/j.jort.2021.100426
- Wesstrom, S., **Creany, N.**, Monz, C. A., Miller, A., & D'Antonio, A. (2021). The Effect of a Vehicle Diversion Traffic Management Strategy on Spatio-Temporal Park Use: A Study in Rocky Mountain National Park, Colorado, Usa. *Journal of Park and Recreation Administration*. doi: 10.18666/jpra-2021-10746

## Manuscripts in Preparation

- **Creany, N.**, Monz, C. - Direct Trail Management on High-Use Trails Improves the Quality of Recreation Experiences. Target Journal: *Landscape and Urban Planning*.

## Natural Resource & Technical Reports

- Graham, R., Creany, N., & Monz, C. (2021). *Spatial Behavior of Backcountry Anglers and Hikers in Rocky Mountain National Park* [Natural Resource Technical Report]. National Park Service.
- Sisneros-Kidd, A., D'Antonio, A. L., Creany, N., Monz, C. A., & Shoenleber, C. (2019). *Recreation Use and Human Valuation on the Nature Reserve of Orange County, California*. Orange County, California: Utah State University.

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## Professional Affiliations

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| • Ecological Society of America (ESA) | 2022-Present |
| • Recreation Ecology Research Network | 2019-Present |
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## Professional Service

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| <b>Associate Editor</b><br><i>Journal of Outdoor Recreation and Tourism</i> | 2026 - Present |
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- Manage and referee the peer review process, ensuring high standards for research quality, robustness, and relevance.

**Journal Peer Reviewer** 2024-Present  
*Scientific Reports*

- Peer-reviewed manuscripts related to recreation management.

**Journal Peer Reviewer** 2021 - Present  
*Journal of Park and Recreation Administration*

- Peer-reviewed manuscripts concerning the application of mobile device data for recreation use estimation.

**Journal Peer Reviewer** 2022 - Present  
*Landscape and Urban Planning*

- Peer-reviewed manuscripts related to park and protected area planning and management.

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## Teaching Experience

**Data Analysis and Programming for Natural Resource Management** Spring 2024  
*Instructor of Record: NR6580* Utah State University

**Wildland Recreation Behavior** Fall 2024  
*Instructor of Record: ENVS 4500* Utah State University

**Wildland Recreation Behavior** Fall 2022  
*Instructor of Record: ENVS 4500* Utah State University

**Wildland Recreation Behavior** Fall 2021  
*Instructor of Record: ENVS 4500* Utah State University

**Wildland Recreation Behavior** Fall 2020  
*Instructor of Record: ENVS 4500* Utah State University

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## Technical Skills

### Programming Languages

*Python, R, ArcPy, SAS*

### Software

*Google Cloud Compute, Google Earth Engine, ArcGIS, QGIS, Adobe CC, LaTeX, Quarto*